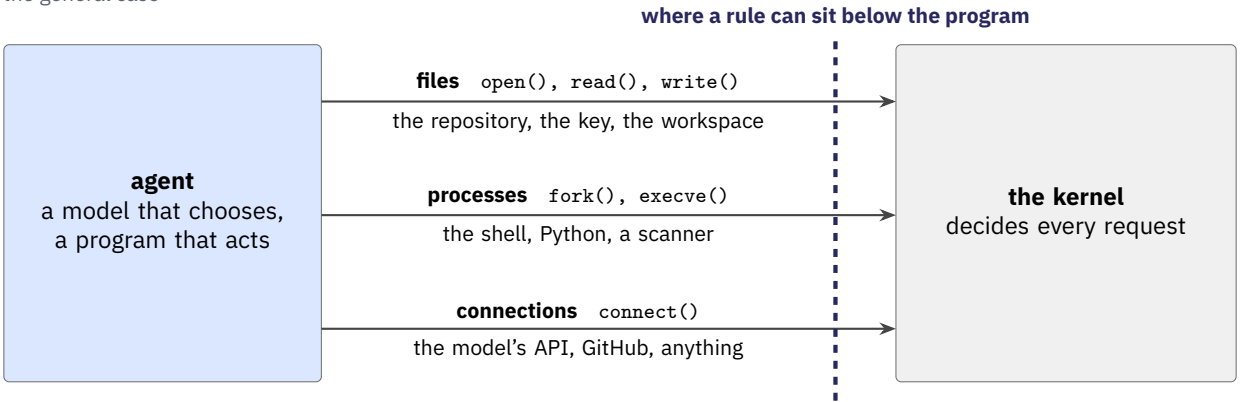the general case